THE MOBILE ADVANTAGE

Cheap handsets, internet penetration and affordable data have placed a mobile phone in almost every hand in the country

By **M.G. ARUN**



THE DRUDGERY

On July 31, 1995, when the then West Bengal chief minister Jyoti Basu made India's first mobile phone call from Writers' Building in Kolkata to the then Union telecom minister Sukh Ram at the Sanchar Bhawan in New Delhi, little did anyone know the instrument would become a great leveller in the next few decades. Certainly not when you had to dish out roughly Rs 4,900 for a pre-paid SIM card and pay a calling rate of Rs 17 per minute at peak traffic hours for incoming or outgoing calls, beyond the purse of the aam aadmi. Internet telephony? Beyond the pale of their imagination. The advent of 3G in 2001 brought with it global roaming, email and video streaming on mobile phones, and that of 4G in 2012, high definition (HD) streaming, social media, and interactive apps. But the cost of mobile data was still Rs 269 per GB in March 2014.

CELLULAR TELEPHONY
Launched in 1995

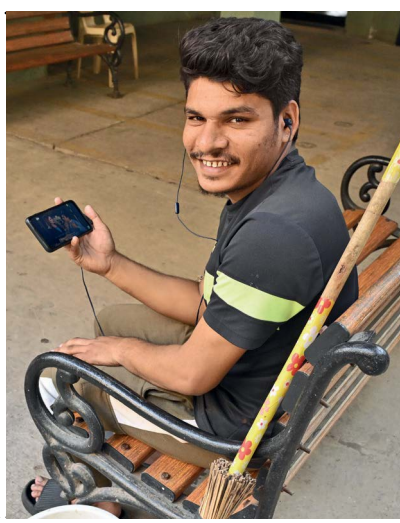
Achievement: India has among the cheapest mobile data in the world, at a mere Rs 9.08 per GB

HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"I pay only Rs 349 for monthly recharge"

Natives of Gujarat, Rohit and his family have been living in Mumbai for 10 years now. He and his parents work as sweepers in three housing societies in Sion Koliwada. Earning Rs 30,000 a month, they live in a rented apartment. Mornings are busy for Rohit, and late evenings go in attending night college in Mahim, where he is studying for Class 12. Afternoons are when he has time for himself, which he spends watching cricket or Bollywood movies on his RealMe 8 5G phone, which he bought for Rs 25,000 some three years ago on EMI. His 5G Airtel connection helps him make the best use of his phone and watch all his

ROHIT SOLANKI, 25
Sweeper, Sion Koliwada, Mumbai



MANDAR DEODHAR